

Your First 10 *Cookie Buyers*

Where to find your first ten paying buyers when you don't have an Instagram following, a portfolio or an ad budget. With seven word-for-word scripts, five objection rebuttals and the first-order checklist.

- The seven no-cost channels that convert without paid ads
- Seven customisable outreach scripts you can send today
- Five objection rebuttals to the pushback you'll actually hear
- The inquiry-to-paid-order checklist that keeps you from losing a sale

First bonus of the five

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This bonus is the shortest possible bridge between "I bake beautiful cookies" and "I have paying customers." Everything in it can be executed with your phone. There is no course-selling nonsense about "building your brand" or "waiting until you're ready." You are ready. Ten buyers is a very small number. Send the messages.

The mindset before you send the first message

Why beginners freeze at the outreach step, and the three sentences that unfreeze it.

There are two moments where nine out of ten students stop making progress in this business. The first is the transition from "I want to start" to "I baked my first batch." The second is the transition from "I have cookies to sell" to "I sent someone a message asking if they want to buy them." This chapter is about the second one.

The three sentences you have to accept

Sentence one: **every professional cookie baker had to ask their first ten buyers.** There is no home-based baking business in America, Britain, Canada or Australia that skipped the awkward "hey, would you be interested in buying some cookies from me" stage. Every single one went through it. Yours doesn't get a special exception.

Sentence two: **the people you're going to message are not doing you a favour by buying — you're doing them a favour by offering.** Your neighbour, your daughter's teacher, your former coworker, the woman you sat next to in a PTA meeting — they all have birthdays, kids, work parties, hostess gifts to bring, teacher appreciation events, wedding showers coming up. You are handing them a solution to something they'd otherwise be Googling at 11pm the night before.

Sentence three: **the worst thing anyone can say is "no, thank you."** That's it. Nobody is going to be angry at you for offering. Nobody is going to tell your other contacts. In the two years I coached students through their first outreach, exactly zero of them received a mean response. Zero. The perceived risk is 100% imaginary.

THE RE-READ TRICK

If you find yourself stalling before sending, re-read the three sentences above out loud. Not in your head — out loud, in your voice. Something changes when you say them. Then hit send.

What "first 10 buyers" actually means

Ten paying orders. Not ten inquiries, not ten "wow, that looks amazing," not ten Instagram likes. Ten people who transferred money and received cookies. Once you have those ten, everything downstream changes: you have a portfolio of ten real photos, ten testimonials to ask for, ten mouths that will mention you to their friends, and ten confirmations to yourself that this is a real business.

You are not building a customer base at this stage. You are building *proof* — proof to yourself, proof to your family who's watching sceptically, proof to the algorithm the day you start posting on Instagram.

CHAPTER 2

Where your first 10 buyers actually live

Seven no-cost channels ranked by conversion rate. You will hit ten from this list in the first two weeks if you work them in this order.

Every one of these channels costs zero dollars. Every one of them can be worked from your phone. Every one of them has produced first paying customers for the students I've walked through this. Work them in this order.

RANK	CHANNEL	TYPICAL CONVERSION	TIMELINE TO FIRST ORDER
1	Immediate family and closest friends	60-80%	Same week
2	Extended family and school/college friends	25-40%	1-2 weeks
3	Current or former coworkers (personal Instagram DM or text)	15-25%	1-3 weeks
4	Parents at your kids' school (school pickup line, PTA)	10-20%	2-4 weeks
5	Local Facebook groups (mums' groups, neighbourhood buy-nothing, foodie groups)	3-8%	1-4 weeks
6	Instagram DMs to local wedding / event planners	1-4%	3-8 weeks
7	Etsy listing (only after 15+ photographed orders)	<1% ordinarily	Month 4+

Rank 1 • Immediate family and closest friends

Your mother, your sister, your best friend, your best friend's sister, your best friend's mother. This is the group where you start. They will not "buy out of pity" — they will buy because the cookies are actually beautiful and they have three birthdays coming up in the next four weeks. Send a text or a photo with a straightforward pitch. Nine times out of ten one of them will place an order within a week.

Rank 2 • Extended family and old friends

College friends, cousins, aunts, church friends, book-club members, gym friends. Everyone you'd casually text about weekend plans falls in this group. Individual texts with a photo attached and one sentence of context convert two-to-four out of ten.

Rank 3 • Coworkers and former coworkers

Your current colleagues from your day job (if you still have one) or your last three former workplaces. Office birthdays, retirement parties, corporate baby showers, client appreciation events — every workplace has these. A single message to one former colleague who hosts events at her company can produce your biggest ticket of the first six months.

Rank 4 • School parents

The single highest-value long-term channel for a home baker who's also a parent. Teacher appreciation weeks (May in US/CA, June in UK), end-of-year events, class parties, birthday party favours for classmates, PTA fundraisers. Introduce yourself once, hand out a card with your Instagram, and become the "cookie mom" every parent knows. This one channel produces a repeat customer base that will carry your business for years.

Rank 5 • Local Facebook groups

Post carefully. Never spam. Read the group rules first — many local groups have a "no promoting your business" rule, and posting your business in violation gets you banned from the group permanently. In groups that allow it, one photo post per week maximum, showing a finished order (with the customer's permission), with a soft caption like "Just delivered these for a client's baby shower — DMing me is the fastest way to order." Never post "buy from me!" language.

Rank 6 • Wedding and event planners

Longer lead time, bigger tickets when they land. Follow local event-planning Instagram accounts, engage genuinely on their posts for a couple of weeks, then send a DM introducing your product with three of your best photos. Convert rate is low but a single planner who adds you to her preferred-vendor list is worth a dozen individual customers.

Rank 7 • Etsy

Not for beginners. Etsy is a portfolio-driven marketplace where you need ten to twenty professional-quality photos to compete. Come back to Etsy in month six when you have that catalogue.

TEN BUYERS, ONE WEEK — THE MATH

If you message fifteen people in Rank 1 and Rank 2, at 40-60% conversion you'll book six-to-nine orders. Add three coworkers or school parents (Rank 3-4) at 15-25% and you'll pick up one more. That's your ten. It is genuinely that mechanical.

The seven outreach scripts (copy-paste ready)

Word-for-word messages you can send today. Fill in the placeholders {curly braces} with the recipient's info. Never send more than one message per day to the same person.

These seven scripts cover every situation you'll encounter in the first two weeks. Copy them into your notes app, replace the placeholders, and send.

Script 1 • Immediate family / closest friends

TEXT OR DM • TONE: CASUAL

Hey {first_name} — quick thing. I've been baking decorated cookies as a real side business and I'm officially open for orders. Sending you a couple of photos because you always have something going on 😊. Do you have anything coming up in the next couple of months where these would fit? Birthday, party, teacher gift, hostess gift, anything? Even if not right now — just a heads-up so you know I'm doing this.

Script 2 • Extended family / older friends

TEXT OR DM • TONE: WARM, INFORMATIVE

Hi {first_name}! Hope you're doing well. Wanted to share some news — I started taking orders for decorated cookies. I know your family's always got birthdays and school events going on, so figured I'd let you know first. Attaching a couple of recent ones. If you ever have something coming up where custom cookies would be fun, I'd love to make them for you. No rush, just wanted you to have it on your radar.

Script 3 • Coworker or former coworker (individual)

DM OR SLACK OR TEXT • TONE: PROFESSIONAL BUT FRIENDLY

Hi {first_name} — random reach-out but wanted to share. I've been baking custom decorated cookies for a while and I'm officially taking orders now. I'm thinking corporate events, client gifts, team birthdays and baby showers are probably up your alley given the events {company_name} runs. If you're the person who orders things like that, I'd love to be on your list. Happy to send samples if that helps. Photos attached.

Script 4 • School parent (in person, after school pickup)

IN PERSON • TONE: BRIEF, DON'T OVERSELL

"Hey {first_name} — I've been meaning to mention. I bake decorated cookies as a small business now. I know teacher appreciation week is coming up / I know {kid_name}'s birthday is next month — if you ever want to do custom cookies for something like that, I'd love to make them. I'll follow up with a photo on Instagram so you can see the style."

(Follow up that evening with an Instagram DM with three photos + your booking link if you have one.)

Script 5 • Local Facebook group post

FACEBOOK POST • TONE: SOFT, NO DIRECT ASK

Just delivered these custom cookies for a client's {occasion} this weekend and I'm still smiling looking at them 🍪 If anyone here has an upcoming birthday, wedding shower, baby announcement or corporate event, I'm now taking orders. Based in {city/area}, I deliver locally and ship regionally. Message me directly with your date and theme — I usually reply within a few hours. Photos below.

Script 6 • Wedding / event planner cold DM (Instagram)

INSTAGRAM DM • TONE: PROFESSIONAL, BRIEF

Hi {planner_name} — love the {name_of_recent_event} setup you posted last week, the palette was gorgeous. I'm a custom-cookie baker based in {city} and I wanted to introduce myself. I do wedding and event favours, dessert-table cookies and branded corporate pieces. Attaching three photos below of recent work. If you ever have a client looking for a custom cookie partner, I'd love the chance to quote a project for you. No pressure at all — happy just being on your radar.

Script 7 • Follow-up after 5 days of silence

TEXT OR DM • TONE: LIGHT, NO GUILT

Hey {first_name} — just checking back in on the cookies. No pressure at all if the timing isn't right or if you've got another baker sorted. Just wanted to make sure my earlier message didn't get buried. Either way, hope your week's going well.

RULES FOR USING THESE SCRIPTS

(1) Send one at a time, personalise the placeholders — never send a bulk broadcast. (2) Attach 2-3 recent photos, never more than 5. (3) Never chase more than once. If they don't reply to Script 7, leave them alone for six months. (4) Do not lie about being "the best" or "the only" cookie baker in your area — just be normal.

Handling the five objections you'll actually hear

Word-for-word rebuttals to the pushback that shows up in most inquiries. Read these before you reply to anything.

You will hear each of these at least twice in your first month. Prepare the answer once, use it forever.

Objection 1 • "That's a bit more than I was hoping to spend"

Do not immediately drop your price. This is the single most expensive mistake beginners make. Instead:

REPLY

Totally understand — decorated cookies are a specialty item and the price reflects the time each one takes to hand-decorate. If it helps, a couple of options: I can do a smaller order (say 12 instead of 24) which brings the total down, or I can do a simpler design (single-colour flood + monogram) which is faster to produce and I can price accordingly. Let me know which fits and I'll re-quote.

Objection 2 • "I can buy cookies at the supermarket for way less"

REPLY

You absolutely can. Supermarket cookies are a great choice for casual snacking. What I make is a different product — hand-decorated custom pieces designed to be the centrepiece of a party dessert table or a personalised gift. The comparison is more like a supermarket birthday cake vs. a custom bakery one. If custom is what you're looking for, I'd love to make yours. If not, no hard feelings at all.

Objection 3 • "Can you match this Pinterest photo exactly?"

REPLY

Love the inspiration! Two honest things: (1) I can get very close to that style, but every cookie decorator has a slightly different hand, so it won't be a photocopy. (2) The Pinterest photo was probably taken under professional lighting — the actual cookies would have looked slightly different in real life too. If you're happy with "in the same style, my interpretation of it," I'd love to make them. If you specifically need that exact decorator, I'd recommend reaching out to the original source.

Objection 4 • "I can bake and decorate them myself"

REPLY

Absolutely — a lot of people love the process and results are so rewarding. The reason customers come to me is the time and equipment: a batch of 24 decorated cookies takes me about 6 hours across two days including drying time. If you have the weekend to invest, you'll love making them. If you'd rather have them delivered and focus on the rest of your event, that's where I come in.

Objection 5 • "Can you deliver next-day?"

REPLY

Honest answer — no, and here's why: royal icing needs 18-24 hours to fully harden before packaging. If I made yours today and delivered tomorrow, the icing would still be slightly soft and the cookies would smudge in transit. My minimum lead time is {your_minimum, usually 5-7 days} to make sure yours look exactly like the photos. If you're on a tight deadline this time, I can point you to a local bakery that does short-notice — but if the date works, I'd love to make yours properly.

THE ONE OBJECTION YOU NEVER NEGOTIATE ON

The deposit. If a customer asks you to skip the 50% deposit "because they promise to pay on delivery," the answer is a friendly no. Every single time. This is the rule that separates hobbyists from businesses. Send them the payment link and wait for the deposit. If they don't send it, there was never an order.

Referral asks after every delivery

The single script that turns your first ten buyers into your first thirty.

Ninety percent of home bakers do not ask for referrals. That's why their businesses stay stuck at ten buyers instead of growing to thirty. Fix this one thing and your customer count doubles by month four.

The 3-5 day follow-up

Between 3 and 5 days after delivery, send the customer a follow-up message. Timing matters — earlier than 3 days feels pushy, later than 5 days feels forgotten. Send this:

TEXT OR DM · TONE: WARM, BRIEF

Hi {first_name}! Just checking in — hope the cookies were a hit at {event_name}. If you got a moment to send me a photo of them at the party, I'd love it (with your permission I'd love to post one or two on my Instagram). And if you'd feel comfortable, one huge favour — do you know one or two people who'd appreciate custom cookies for something coming up? Kids' birthdays, baby showers, work events, anything really. Word of mouth is genuinely how this business grows. Either way, thank you so much for supporting me on this — I really appreciate it.

What you're actually asking for

Three things in one message: (1) a photo of the cookies in situ at the event, which is your best possible marketing content, (2) permission to post said photo, and (3) a referral. Most customers happily give you all three. About 40% will send a photo. About 25% will name at least one person you can follow up with.

The referral follow-up

When your customer says "you should reach out to my sister-in-law Sarah, she's got a baby shower coming up," ask for Sarah's contact and permission to mention who referred you.

DM TO SARAH

Hi Sarah — {referrer_name} passed your name along and mentioned you have a baby shower coming up. I'm a home baker specialising in custom decorated cookies. {referrer_name} just ordered {her_order} from me last week and thought yours might be a fun fit. Sending a few photos of recent orders. Would love to quote yours if the timing's right. No pressure at all — feel free to just save my info for later.

The first-order operational checklist

The complete first-order workflow. Print this and stick it inside a kitchen cabinet.

Inquiry received

1. Reply within 4 business hours ✓
2. Ask the five questions: date, quantity, theme/colours, allergies, delivery or pickup ✓
3. Confirm you're available on the date ✓

Quote sent

4. Itemised total (unit price × quantity) + delivery fee if applicable ✓
5. 50% deposit link (Stripe / PayPal / Venmo / bank transfer) ✓
6. Delivery or pickup date and time (working backwards from the event) ✓
7. Ingredient allergen list on record ✓

Deposit arrived — order is now confirmed

8. Send a "confirmed" message with the exact delivery date ✓
9. Add the order to your calendar with a bake date and a package date ✓
10. Order any special supplies (colour matches, custom sprinkles) ✓

Production

- | | |
|---|---|
| 11. Bake day (5-7 days before delivery) | ✓ |
| 12. Decorate day (3-5 days before delivery) | ✓ |
| 13. Dry 24 hours | ✓ |
| <hr/> | |
| 14. Package day (1-2 days before delivery) | ✓ |

Handoff

- | | |
|---|---|
| 15. Send "your order is ready" photo the day before | ✓ |
| 16. Deliver or hand off at the agreed time | ✓ |
| 17. Collect remaining 50% at handoff (or confirm it's already paid) | ✓ |
| <hr/> | |
| 18. Follow up 3-5 days later — photo + referral ask (Chapter 5) | ✓ |

WHAT THIS LIST PROTECTS YOU FROM

Cancelled orders, disputed payments, allergic reactions, forgotten dates, last-minute panic. If you follow the eighteen steps every time, you will not lose an order in the first two years. Skip any one of them and eventually you will.

CLOSING

Your first 10-buyer week

The seven-day plan that gets you from zero customers to booked-through-the-month.

DAY	ACTION
Monday	List 20 people to reach out to — family (5), close friends (5), coworkers (5), school parents (5).
Tuesday	Send Script 1 to the 5 family members. Send Script 2 to the 5 close friends.
Wednesday	Send Script 3 to the 5 coworkers.
Thursday	Send Script 4 in person (or DM version) to the 5 school parents.
Friday	Reply to every inquiry that came in. Send quotes with deposit links.
Saturday	Bake and decorate first confirmed orders.
Sunday	Send Script 7 (follow-up) to anyone who hasn't replied. Post one photo of your work in one local Facebook group (Script 5).

If you execute this week honestly, you'll finish it with 3-6 confirmed orders and a pipeline of 4-8 more warm conversations. That is your first ten.

Send the first message today

You've read the scripts. You have the list. The only thing between you and your first paying customer is the ten seconds it takes to press send.

Next bonus to open

Once your first orders are coming in, open **Bonus 3 · Store to Sell** for the production system that lets you handle three orders at once without losing your mind.